I hardly scored runs – 35 against the same Tertius Bosch and Northern Transvaal in the return game at Centurion Park was my highest score. It was a very frustrating time for me. I knew I was out of my league. I was just basically trying to survive. Walking out onto the field for that first game against Northern Transvaal at Newlands, I couldn't even feel my legs, I was so bladdy nervous.

I would be standing in the middle, at the end of an over, with senior players like Brian McMillan and Kenny Jackson, who'd try to give me advice, but their words would just go through me completely. I was far too nervous to comprehend anything they said. I was still way too young for this level of the game, and I found it really tough to make such a huge adjustment so quickly. I got nine in my first innings and 14 in my second in that first game for Province. I guess Daryll Cullinan is probably the only other cricketer who can relate to my experience, as he also began his first-class career at the age of 16 (for Border, in 1983).

It didn't help that I was also feeling the weight of expectation to perform. I was seen as a talented prodigy who, if he didn't score 50 or 100, had failed. I've had that my entire career. The fans can be demanding. It's almost like no matter what you get, it isn't good enough. I could come off three or four 100s in a row and the next innings I don't score and everyone's like, 'Well, what happened?' I'm also very conscious of the fact that people pay good money to watch me play. No one is more disappointed when I don't score runs than me. But that's cricket; no one in the world scores a 100 every time they go in to bat.

Knowing that some of the games were on TV was an additional burden. Being on telly was new to me – the knowledge that hundreds of thousands of people were watching me bat just added to my nervousness. It definitely took a while to get used to that!

The coaches obviously realised I had concerns and I was selected to play only three A-section games in that first season. I did, however, play in quite a few Benson & Hedges limited-over games. In the first game I played in that competition, they cocked up my name on the back of my shirt. It said 'Dibb' instead of Gibbs. Come to think of it, concealing my identity in that first, patchy season wasn't necessarily a bad thing.

But ja, I felt a lot more at home in the B-section, as I was more comfortable with that level of cricket. In those first years I knew that I couldn't yet hold my own in the top-flight provincial four-day game. The B-